



Technical skill is different. In most cases, it correlates closely with hours of practice — like the 10,000-hour rule to become elite. For example, if you watch five to six-year-old kids playing with a ball, you will notice huge differences in hand-eye coordination. This is probably caused more by differences in hours of practice than natural talent. Some kids start playing as soon as they can crawl and soon clock hundreds of hours. Others never gain that experience. So it can be hard to separate natural talent from natural interest.

Still, the existence of prodigies shows us that natural talent in physical skill acquisition is real. Some kids learn sports techniques way faster than others — even with equal training. Also, the speed of skill acquisition may depend on athleticism. In tennis or cricket, proper stroke technique requires some baseline level of speed, power,

balance, and agility. I've seen many cricketers decline in their technical skill over time — not because they were out of practice, but because their athleticism declined.

Skill vs Structure

Good technique is also affected by the body's physiology — something often overlooked in discussions around coordination. Good skill or technique can only be acquired when the body is aligned with the right movement patterns. If the body is not moving in the right way, it takes time to adapt the movement pattern through more practice.

Another clue that physical structure plays a big role in coordination is our intuitive ability to identify good athletes based purely on appearance — even when they're not performing. This could be called genetic physiological loading. Many times, we see someone on the street who gives the impression of being a professional athlete — and

Game ready: Many elite athletes don't train much aside from just playing their sport. For example, Sachin Tendulkar avoided heavy weight training in his early years. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

sometimes, we're fooled by the structure. Generally speaking, it comes down to proportional build or simply the way they move.

Skill vs Passion and Psychology

Passion and psychology also play a key role in how fast someone learns a skill. Passionate people spend enormous amounts of time focussing intensely on perfecting a skill. An example I read about: when Tiger Woods was a kid, he used to watch his dad practise his golf swing. As he grew older, he'd even ask his driver to stop the car during long trips so he could step out and practise swings on the roadside. His natural talent, passion, and psychology were all interconnected.